

Cultural Dimensions

In 1980 Professor Geert Hofstede, a Dutch psychologist who had been working for IBM, published his work *Culture's Consequences* that was derived from analysing data collected from over 100,000 employees at IBM subsidiaries in forty nations. This was the largest and most comprehensive study at the time and its reception was varied – from enthusiastic to sceptical. By the late 1980s the idea of cultural dimensions had become normal science. Today Hofstede's dimensions have become part of intercultural training programmes and are included in textbooks and readers in cross-cultural psychology, organizational psychology, sociology, management and communications.

Hofstede defined the idea that cultural dimensions can be determined at the national level and compared to other cultures. He used continua to contrast differences in order to demonstrate how a particular country could be more or less of any particular dimension – for example, some countries, such as the United States, generally tend to be more individualist in their social make-up. Individualist cultures are inclined to have looser ties within the community and weaker interpersonal connections, whereas collectivist groups generally have stronger group cohesion, loyalty and responsibility for members of the group.

Hofstede initially described four separate dimensions: power distance, individualism and collectivism, uncertainty avoidance, and masculinity and femininity. Later, the model was extended by two dimensions in collaboration with Michael Bond (long-term orientation) and most recently Michael Minkov (indulgence vs. restraint).

The following is an overview of Hofstede's first four dimensions: power distance, individualism versus collectivism, uncertainty avoidance, masculinity versus femininity.

- Power Distance

Power distance examines how people deal with inequality in their society. While power and inequality exist in all societies, some are more unequal than others.

Hofstede derived power-distance scores for three regions and fifty countries from the answers given by IBM employees in the same type of positions to the same questions. Power Distance Index (PDI) was calculated. The PDI is designed to measure the extent to which power differs within the society, organization, and institutions is accepted by less powerful members. The index assigns a score to each country that indicates its level of power distance and dependent relationships. The PDI also represents society's level of inequality that is defined from below rather than from above. The PDI uses relative values; it is only useful when comparing countries.

Hofstede found that the emotional distance is relatively small in lower PDI cultures. There

are more democratic or consultative relations between expecting and accepting power. People are relatively interdependent to the power holders, and there is a relatively low inequality of power distributed among the people. Under these circumstances, the decentralized authority and flat management structure is common but not universal, which suggests that managers and subordinates will, on average, be relatively less concerned with status, and the distribution of decision-making responsibility is extensive. Policies like the "open door" policy are implemented more often, which influence higher-ranking individuals to be more receptive to lower-ranking individuals, and subordinates to be more likely to challenge or give suggestions to their superiors. Examples of countries with low PDIs include the Netherlands, the United Kingdom, the United States, Germany, and the Nordic countries.

In higher PDI cultures, the power relations are paternalistic and autocratic, and centralized authority exists; there is a wide gap or emotional distance which is perceived to exist among people at different levels of the hierarchy. There is considerable dependence (also known as counter-dependence) on individuals who hold power. In the workplace, subordinates are willing to accept their inferior positions, and superiors may not ask for broad participation in the decision-making process. Higher PDI cultures usually adopt an autocratic leadership style, which means subordinates may be unlikely to approach and contradict their bosses directly. Countries with high power distance cultures usually believe that there is nothing wrong with inequality and everyone has specific positions. China, Belgium, France, Malaysia, and the Arab world are regarded as examples of countries or regions with high PDI cultures.

● Individualism versus Collectivism

This dimension deals with how people interact on a social level, and the default system compels people to think in terms of 'me' or 'we'.

Societies on the individualist side of the continuum tend to have fewer interpersonal connections beyond family and close friends; therefore, people act in their own interest first and have less personal responsibility for other's well-being. Usually, the state has a stronger role in more individualist societies (for example by providing social security, replacing the need for belonging to in-groups). Societies tend to become more individualistic the wealthier they become.

Strengths of individualism	Weaknesses of individualism
Freedom and Autonomy: Individualism promotes personal freedom and autonomy, where individuals are encouraged to pursue their own path in life.	Social Isolation: Individualism means that societies tend not to feel the need to look after one another to the same extent as collectivist cultures. This leads to social isolation for vulnerable and marginalized people.
Innovation and Creativity: Individualistic	Inequality: Individualism celebrates success

societies tend to embrace and celebrate innovation and creativity. Independent thinking and a unique identity are encouraged.	and wealth, but this can also lead to social and economic inequality as it embraces competition and self-interest over collective welfare.
Personal Growth and Self-Reliance: Personal achievements tend to be celebrated and encouraged. Individuals are lauded for their achievements and their successes are rewarded.	Lack of Support: In highly individualistic societies, there might be a lack of social support such as a social safety net, universal welfare system, etc.
Direct Communication: Individualistic cultures tend to be low-context in communication styles, meaning they typically favor direct communication, which tends to be very efficient for productivity and problem-solving in workplace cultures.	Potential for Conflict: The emphasis on personal rights and freedoms and less focus on conformity means interpersonal clashes are less taboo.

Individuals living in societies on the collectivist side tend to have stronger ties with the family and extended family structures. There is strong commitment, loyalty, respect and obedience to the group, which is rewarded in terms of protection and inclusion and sanctioned through strong social control. Expectations of more collectivist societies generally mean that members are expected to act on the behalf of the good of the group – not the self. For example, the mainly Southern African concept of Ubuntu means that ‘I am by virtue of many.’ It is the reciprocal hospitality and collaboration that supports and benefits everyone. In African cultures, this concept generally suggests that people strive for a win-win situation – ‘when you win, I win; when you hurt, I hurt’.

Strengths of collectivism	Weaknesses of collectivism
Group Cohesion and Support: Collectivism has a strong focus on group bonds and mutual support among the group's community members.	Suppression of Individuality: Unfortunately, collectivism tends to suppress expressions of individuality, where it's often frowned upon or seen as abnormal.
Collective Welfare: Collective welfare is prioritized highly, and the individual is expected to have a responsibility to the group. This tends to reduce social and economic inequalities.	Resistance to Change: Collectivist societies may be more resistant to change than individualistic societies because change is seen as having the potential to upend the balance of group harmony.
Conflict Avoidance: Collectivist cultures tend to avoid conflict, instead choosing to prioritize the group's harmony. This often	Groupthink: When a society highly values consensus, it can fall into groupthink, where people are expected to accept the

leads to non-confrontational conflict resolution strategies and the use of implied disciplinary strategies such as social shaming.	dominant viewpoint uncritically.
Respect for Traditions: Collectivist cultures have strong respect for their elders and the traditions that have served them well for generations, providing a sense of continuity and predictability.	Pressure to Conform: People in these societies can feel intense pressure to conform, including from their parents, which potentially leads people to feeling lack of personal fulfillment in their lives.

● Uncertainty Avoidance

Uncertainty is part of life because no one can know the future. However, some cultures deal with it differently than others. Normally the highest degree of uncertainty is found in collective societies because of the need to act interdependently and because beliefs and institutional systems have been created to provide structure, behavioural codes, rules and laws. In more uncertainty avoidant countries like Germany or Japan official credentials are extremely important. They are meant to provide certainty. For example, toothpaste commercials will usually include a dentist, acting as the expert, recommending the product.

There is a wide scale on where specific cultures fall under the uncertainty avoidance. Three types of uncertainty avoidance are high, low, and moderate uncertainty avoidance. Hofstede's uncertainty avoidance scale shows the want to reduce any visible uncertainty that is placed in the life of a person.

High uncertainty avoidance

There are many ways to detect if someone has a high amount of uncertainty avoidance. Typically, the use of formality in interaction with others, dependence of formalized policies and procedures, apparent resistance to change, and intolerance of nontraditional ways are all characteristics of high uncertainty avoidance.

Also, people from high uncertainty avoidance cultures demonstrate higher stress and anxiety levels. These individuals have a high value on control, which means that having a set structure in everything of their life helps. The use of rigid rules assists them with defining what they believe in and how they behave. The development of new ideas makes them uncomfortable and only take risks that they know have high success rates. Older people in high UA are highly respected and feared. When children are being taught the beliefs of their culture, they cannot question them. People in high uncertainty avoidance societies may be afraid of people who are different from them. They may show signs of Xenophobia.

Some of the highest uncertainty avoidance countries include Finland, Germany, Greece, Guatemala, Japan, Mexico, Portugal, and South Korea.

Low uncertainty avoidance

In contrast, people can also exhibit characteristics of low uncertainty avoidance. Unlike high UA, those with a low level use informality in interaction with others, they often rely on informal norms and behaviors in most matters. Also, they will show moderate resistance to change.

Individuals that come from a culture with low UA care about letting the future come without the control or plan of it. Rules that are placed do not have an influence on them. Those with a low UA believe that it is okay to question the people in higher positions. They have lower stress and anxiety rates. Younger people in low UA are respected and when they are being taught the beliefs within their culture, they do not have to follow them right away. When new ideas are brought up, they are open-minded when hearing about them. People from low UA don't find situations that aren't clear as problems that might cause them trouble. Originality will have higher value and likely to be taken into consideration. Additionally, people with low uncertainty avoidance do not have any difficulty with interacting with people who are different from them.

Some of the lowest uncertainty avoidance countries include Jamaica, Denmark, Singapore, Sweden, and Ireland.

- Masculinity versus Femininity

Masculinity and femininity are based upon the Latinized words for manlike and womanlike. A 'masculine' culture refers to a society that values competition, achievement and success, which are typically considered masculine roles, whereas a 'feminine' culture values cooperation and caring. This means that in masculine cultures the emotional gender roles are distinct – boys should be assertive and grow up to be focused on material success; girls are encouraged to focus on the quality of life. In a feminine culture there is less role separation – where men can be modest, tender and focused on the quality of life. For example, in more feminine cultures, such as Sweden, Norway and Finland, there are strong national laws that allow fathers to take almost as long paternal leave for a newborn child as the mother. Fathers, in general, take on an important role in child-rearing.

The following table reflects traditional views on masculinity and femininity.

	Masculinity	Femininity

Typical Gender Stereotypes	Strong, assertive, independent, competitive, emotionally reserved.	Gentle, nurturing, cooperative, sensitive, emotionally expressive.
Roles in Society (traditional view)	Expected to be providers, protectors, leaders, decision-makers.	Expected to be caregivers, supporters, followers, empathetic listeners.
Emotional Expression	Traditionally discouraged from showing emotions (except anger). Often told to “man up”.	Encouraged to express emotions freely. Associated with empathy and compassion.
Communication	Direct, assertive. Prefers to solve problems independently.	Indirect, cooperative. Prefers collaboration and discussion.
Occupations (traditional view)	Careers in politics, science, engineering, military, business.	Careers in nursing, teaching, social work, fashion, beauty.
Relationship to Power	More likely to seek power, assert dominance, and take up space.	Traditionally less likely to seek power, often adopting supportive or subordinate roles.
Physical Appearance (traditional view)	Muscular, tall, short hair, less emphasis on clothing and accessories.	Soft, petite, long hair, more emphasis on clothing, makeup, and accessories.

Essentially, what is considered masculine or feminine can vary greatly from one culture to another. Such cultural ideals are deeply embedded and shape individual behavior, identities, and societal norms at large.

In some societies, the concept of masculinity is strictly tied to physical strength, stoicism, and economic prowess. For instance, in many traditional societies, manual labor and physical strength define a man's masculinity. On the contrary, in other societies, mental strength, emotional intelligence, and the ability to provide for the family define masculinity. An example might be the difference in expression of masculinity between the Maasai warriors

of Kenya, whose rites of passage include lion hunting, and men in Scandinavian cultures, where gender equality and shared household work is emphasized.

Femininity, as well, can exhibit significant cultural variation. In some cultures, femininity is tied to domesticity, gentleness, and passivity. For instance, in many fundamentalist and deeply conservative societies, women's roles are traditionally restricted to the private sphere: homemaking, child-rearing, etc. However, in other cultures, femininity can also be associated with strength, leadership, and independence. The Mosuo culture in China, for instance, is a matrilineal society where women are heads of households, and their economic and social status are more prominent, challenging traditional notions of femininity.

references:

Rings, G., & Rasinger, S. (Eds.). (2020). *The Cambridge handbook of intercultural communication*. Cambridge University Press.

<https://helpfulprofessor.com/collectivism-vs-individualism/>

Vocabulary

序号	英语词汇 (词性)	中文释义
1	subsidiary (n.)	子公司
2	sceptical (adj.)	怀疑的
3	continuum (n. 复数 continua)	连续统, 连续体
4	masculinity (n.)	男性气质
5	femininity (n.)	女性气质
6	decentralize (v.)	去中心化
7	paternalistic (adj.)	家长式统治的, 家长作风的
8	autocratic (adj.)	专制的
9	hierarchy (n.)	等级制度
10	Identity (n.)	身份, 认同
11	conformity (n.)	遵从, 从众
12	reciprocal (adj.)	互惠的
13	upend (v.)	颠倒
14	xenophobia (n.)	排外
15	stereotype (n.)	刻板印象
16	muscular (adj.)	强健的, 肌肉发达的
17	stoicism (n.)	坚忍

18	prowess (n.)	英勇
19	domesticity (n.)	家庭生活
20	fundamentalist (adj.)	原教旨主义的

Exercises

Part I Complete the following paragraph with the most suitable words from the box.

society, fundamentalist, continua, hierarchical, cohesion, autonomy, uncertainty

Hofstede's theory suggests that cultures can be compared along several (1)_____. One key dimension is individualism versus collectivism, which reflects whether people think in terms of "me" or "we". In individualist societies, people tend to value personal freedom and (2)_____, but this may lead to social isolation. In contrast, collectivist cultures emphasize group (3)_____ and mutual support. Another dimension, power distance, examines how inequality is accepted within a (4)_____. In high power distance cultures, authority is often centralized and relationships are more (5)_____.

Part II True or False

1. Hofstede's cultural dimensions were based on data collected from employees working in different positions across various companies worldwide.
2. In low power distance cultures, subordinates are more likely to challenge their managers and participate in decision-making.
3. Individualistic societies usually have stronger social support systems because people care more about collective welfare.
4. People in high uncertainty avoidance cultures tend to prefer clear rules, formal structures, and stability.
5. In feminine cultures, gender roles are more strictly separated, and men are expected to focus on competition and success.

Part III Translate the following paragraph into English, using the words or expressions given.

霍夫斯泰德的文化维度理论认为，不同国家在处理不确定性方面存在差异。在高不确定性规避文化中，人们倾向于依赖正式规则和制度来减少不确定性，并且对变化持抵触态度。这些社会通常重视权威和传统，同时个体的压力和焦虑水平也较高。相反，在低不确定性规避文

化中，人们更加开放，愿意接受新观点，并且对未来的不确定性持更宽容的态度。

(uncertainty avoidance, authority, resistance, individual, adopt)

Part IV Discussion Questions

1. To what extent do Hofstede's cultural dimensions risk oversimplifying cultures by treating them as fixed national characteristics?
2. Is individualism necessarily linked to economic development, or can collectivist values also support modern economic growth?
3. How useful is the concept of power distance in explaining workplace relationships in multinational companies today?